

Here's the full curation for **joke**, anchored to the passage phrase **"half joking and half serious."**
This word has a clear core meaning but branches into humorous remark/story, teasing/not being serious, practical joke, ridicule, and figurative 'a joke' = something ridiculous or inadequate.
The full **MCQ-ready master list** is included.

JOKE

1. Passage anchor

> "I remember she told me, **half joking and half serious**, that I was now old enough to 'write my own story.'"

Passage meaning

joke = say something humorously or not fully seriously
開玩笑；說笑；不是完全認真

Here:

> **half joking**
> = **半開玩笑**

The sister says something in a playful way, but she also genuinely means part of it.

Practice

1. I was only **joking** when I said I would quit.
我說要辭職時只是在**開玩笑**。
2. She sounded as if she was **joking**, but there was some truth in what she said.
她聽起來像是在**說笑**，但她說的話也有幾分認真。

Core noun meanings

2. joke — funny remark or story

= something said or told to make people laugh
笑話；玩笑

Examples

1. He told a funny **joke**.
他講了一個很好笑的**笑話**。

2. I didn't understand the **joke**.

我沒有聽懂那個**笑話**。

This is the central noun sense.

3. tell a joke

= say a humorous story or remark

講笑話

Examples

1. She likes to **tell jokes** at dinner.

她喜歡在吃飯時**講笑話**。

2. He **told a joke** to relax everyone.

他講了一個**笑話**讓大家放鬆。

Verb: speak humorously / not seriously

4. joke — say something for amusement

= say something humorous or playful

開玩笑；說笑

Examples

1. We were **joking** about the situation.

我們拿那件事**開玩笑**。

2. He **joked** that he needed a holiday.

他**開玩笑地說**自己需要放假。

This is the exact passage branch.

5. joke about something

= make humorous comments about something

拿.....開玩笑；說笑

Examples

1. They often **joke about** their old school days.
他們常拿以前的校園生活**開玩笑**。

2. She **joked about** being late again.
她拿自己又遲到這件事**說笑**。

6. joke that...

= say something in a humorous, non-literal, or partly serious way
開玩笑地說.....

Examples

1. He **joked that** he should retire immediately.
他**開玩笑地說**自己應該馬上退休。

2. She **joked that** the bag weighed a ton.
她**開玩笑地說**那個袋子重得像一噸。

Teasing / playful interaction

7. joke with someone

= speak to someone in a playful or humorous way
和某人開玩笑

Examples

1. She often **jokes with** her colleagues.
她常和同事**開玩笑**。

2. I was just **joking with you**.
我只是在**跟你開玩笑**。

8. joking aside

= used to stop joking and become serious
玩笑歸玩笑；說正經的

Examples

1. **Joking aside**, this is a serious problem.
玩笑歸玩笑，這是個嚴重問題。
2. **Joking aside**, we need to make a decision today.
說正經的，我們今天需要作出決定。

Practical joke

9. practical joke

= trick played on someone for amusement
惡作劇；整人玩笑

Examples

1. They played a **practical joke** on their friend.
他們對朋友開了一個**惡作劇玩笑**。
2. The **practical joke** went too far.
那個**惡作劇**玩得太過火了。

Joke at someone's expense

10. joke at someone's expense

= make someone the target of humor, often causing embarrassment
拿某人開玩笑；以某人為笑柄

Examples

1. They made a **joke at his expense**.
他們拿他來**開玩笑**。
2. Humor is less funny when it comes at someone else's **expense**.
如果笑點建立在讓別人難堪之上，就沒那麼好笑了。

A person/thing treated as ridiculous

11. joke — something ridiculous or inadequate

= something so bad, ineffective, or absurd that it should not be taken seriously

****笑話；荒唐的東西；不像樣****

Examples

1. The service was a complete ****joke****.

那個服務簡直是個****笑話****。

2. Their security system is a ****joke****.

他們的保安系統根本****不像樣****。

This is a major figurative sense.

12. be a joke

= be ridiculous, ineffective, or not worthy of respect

****荒唐；不像樣；不值一提****

Examples

1. The whole process is ****a joke****.

整個流程簡直****荒唐透頂****。

2. That so-called solution is ****a joke****.

那個所謂的解決方案根本****不值一提****。

Person treated as ridiculous

13. make a joke of someone/something

= make someone/something seem ridiculous or not serious

****把.....當笑話；使.....顯得可笑****

Examples

1. Don't ****make a joke of**** the situation.

不要把這個情況****當成笑話****。

2. The poor execution ****made a joke of**** the plan.

糟糕的執行讓整個計畫**變得可笑**。

Joke as shared reference

14. inside joke / private joke

= joke understood only by a particular group because of shared knowledge or experience

圈內笑話；只有特定人懂的笑話

Examples

1. It was an **inside joke** between the two of them.

那是他們兩人之間的**私人笑話**。

2. I didn't understand because it was a **private joke**.

我聽不懂，因為那是他們之間的**圈內笑話**。

Long-running joke

15. running joke

= joke that is repeated over time or across a series of events

反覆出現的笑梗；長期笑話

Examples

1. His lateness became a **running joke** in the office.

他老是遲到成了辦公室裡的**長期笑梗**。

2. The series has several **running jokes**.

那套劇有幾個反覆出現的**笑梗**。

Old or familiar joke

16. old joke

= joke that has been heard many times

老笑話；老梗

Examples

1. That's an **old joke**.

那是個**老梗**。

2. He keeps repeating the same **old joke**.

他一直重複同一個**老笑話**。

Bad joke

17. bad joke

A. unfunny joke

不好笑的笑話

B. situation so poor that it feels absurd

荒唐可笑的情況

Examples

1. That was a really **bad joke**.

那真是個**不好笑的笑話**。

2. The whole arrangement felt like a **bad joke**.

整個安排簡直像個**荒唐的鬧劇**。

Joke meaning “not serious”

18. as a joke

= done or said for amusement rather than seriously

當作玩笑；只是說笑

Examples

1. I said it **as a joke**.

我只是**開玩笑說的**。

2. He bought the hat **as a joke**.

他買那頂帽子只是**鬧著玩的**。

19. no joke

= serious, difficult, dangerous, or impressive; not something to laugh about

不是鬧著玩的；很嚴重 / 很厲害

Examples

1. Running a marathon is **no joke**.

跑馬拉松可**不是鬧著玩的**。

2. That exam was **no joke**.

那場考試真的**很難，不是開玩笑的**。

Very useful idiom.

20. no joking matter

= serious issue that should not be treated lightly

不是可以開玩笑的事；嚴肅問題

Examples

1. Safety is **no joking matter**.

安全問題**不是可以拿來開玩笑的**。

2. Losing that amount of money is **no joking matter**.

損失那麼多錢可**不是小事**。

You must be joking

21. you're joking / you must be joking

= expression of disbelief or surprise

你在開玩笑吧；不會吧

Examples

1. "The tickets cost \$500." "You're **joking**!"

「門票要五百元。」「你在**開玩笑吧**！」

2. You **must be joking** if you think I can finish this tonight.

如果你覺得我今晚做得完，你一定是在**開玩笑**。

Often not a literal question about humor.

Can take a joke

22. take a joke

= react calmly to being teased and not become offended

開得起玩笑

Examples

1. He can **take a joke**.

他**開得起玩笑**。

2. If you tease others, you should be able to **take a joke** yourself.

如果你會取笑別人，自己也應該**開得起玩笑**。

Related forms

23. joking

= speaking or behaving humorously rather than seriously

開玩笑的；說笑的

Examples

1. I was **joking**.

我是在**開玩笑**。

2. She spoke in a **joking tone**.

她用**說笑的語氣**說話。

24. jokingly

= in a humorous or non-serious way

開玩笑地；說笑地

Examples

1. He **jokingly** called himself an expert.
他**開玩笑地**自稱專家。
2. She **jokingly** threatened to keep the gift herself.
她**說笑地**威脅要自己留下那份禮物。

25. joker

A. person who often jokes

愛開玩笑的人；搞笑的人

1. He is the office **joker**.
他是辦公室裡的**開心果 / 愛開玩笑的人**。

B. playing card

鬼牌；Joker

2. The deck contains two **jokers**.
這副牌裡有兩張**鬼牌**。

Distinct lexicalized sense.

26. jokey

= humorous, playful, and not serious

愛說笑的；帶玩笑意味的

Examples

1. The conversation had a **jokey** tone.
那段對話帶著**說笑的語氣**。
2. His message was deliberately **jokey**.
他的訊息刻意寫得很**輕鬆搞笑**。

Informal.

Key contrasts

27. joke vs funny story

A **joke** is specifically intended to produce laughter, often with a punchline.

A **funny story** can simply describe an amusing event.

28. joke vs tease

joke

= say something humorous or playful

開玩笑

tease

= deliberately make fun of or provoke someone playfully, sometimes unkindly

逗弄；取笑

Compare:

> We were **joking** together.

> 我們一起說笑。

> They **teased** him about his haircut.

> 他們拿他的髮型取笑他。

29. joke vs prank

joke

= humorous remark/story or playful comment

prank

= trick/action played on someone for amusement

惡作劇

A **practical joke** is close to a **prank**.

30. joke vs sarcasm

****joke****

= intended to amuse

****sarcasm****

= saying something, often the opposite of what is meant, usually to mock or criticize

****諷刺 ; 挖苦****

Not all jokes are sarcastic, and sarcasm is not always playful.

31. joking vs lying

****joking****

= saying something not literally serious for humor, usually with no intention to deceive seriously

****lying****

= deliberately saying something false in order to deceive

Context and intent are crucial.

32. joke vs serious

This is the exact passage contrast.

****joking****

= playful, humorous, not fully literal

****開玩笑的****

****serious****

= genuinely meant

****認真的****

So:

> ****half joking and half serious****

means:

****the comment was playful, but the underlying message was genuine.****

Meaning map

The central concept of **joke** is:

something said or done for amusement rather than full seriousness

From this develop:

Noun

tell a joke

→ **講笑話**

Verb

joke with someone

→ **和某人開玩笑**

Passage

half joking

→ **半開玩笑**

Trick

practical joke

→ **惡作劇**

Shared humor

inside joke

→ **圈內笑話**

Repeated humor

running joke

→ **長期笑梗**

Ridiculous thing

the system is a joke

→ **這系統簡直不像樣**

Serious contrast

no joke

→ **不是鬧著玩的**

Disbelief

you must be joking

→ **你在開玩笑吧**

The passage uses the **non-serious/playful speech** branch.

MCQ-ready master list

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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joke — humorous remark/story	為了讓人發笑而說的話或故事；笑話
tell a joke	講笑話
joke — verb	用幽默、玩笑方式說話；開玩笑
joke about something	拿某事來說笑 / 開玩笑
joke that...	以開玩笑方式說某句話
joke with someone	和某人開玩笑、說笑
joking aside	停止說笑、轉入正經話題；玩笑歸玩笑
practical joke	為取樂而對別人做的惡作劇
joke at someone's expense	拿某人當笑料，使對方難堪
joke — ridiculous thing	糟糕、荒唐到不值得認真看待的事物；笑話
be a joke	荒唐、不像樣、不值得認真對待
make a joke of	把某人 / 某事弄得可笑、不被認真看待
inside/private joke	只有特定群體因共享背景而懂的笑話
running joke	長期反覆出現的笑梗
as a joke	只是鬧著玩 / 當作玩笑
no joke	非常嚴肅、困難或厲害；不是鬧著玩的
no joking matter	嚴肅到不適合拿來開玩笑的事情
you're joking / you must be joking	表示不相信或震驚；「你在開玩笑吧？」
take a joke	被取笑時不生氣；開得起玩笑
joking	開玩笑的；說笑的
jokingly	以玩笑方式；開玩笑地
joker — person	經常開玩笑、逗人笑的人
joker — card	撲克牌中的鬼牌
jokey	帶玩笑意味、輕鬆搞笑的

Passage recap

> “... **half joking and half serious**...”

Here:

****joking** = **speaking in a playful, humorous way rather than being completely serious****

Best Traditional Chinese:

* **開玩笑的**

* **說笑的**

* contextually: **半開玩笑**

Natural contextual translation:

****她當時半開玩笑、半認真地對我說.....****

Passage MCQ-ready meaning

****joke****

= ****to say something humorously or playfully rather than with complete seriousness****

****開玩笑；說笑****

The key contrast is:

> ****joking****

> → 語氣帶玩笑、不是百分之百字面認真

> ****serious****

> → 真正想表達這個意思

So ****half joking and half serious**** means the sister's wording is playful, but the deeper message — that the speaker is beginning to shape their own life — is genuine.